



Japan Monetary Policy Watch

MPM review: an initial dovish interpretation

A dissenting vote suggests a more dovish policy board

The rate hike was approved by a 7-1 vote, with the dissenting vote cast by board member Asada, who was appointed by Prime Minister Takaichi and joined the board just this March. Although we had noted this possibility in our [preview memo](#), it was not our main scenario. It is highly unusual for a board member to express dissent against the governor's proposal so soon—less than three months after taking office.

This action has significant implications for the future composition of the policy board. It is conceivable that the new member, Sato, scheduled to join in June, may also adopt a dovish voting stance. Furthermore, looking ahead to July 2027, the terms of the two most hawkish members, Takata and Tamura, will expire. If Takaichi also leads the appointment of their successors, we expect the board's dovish tilt to become even more pronounced.

Why a 50bp hike was not on the table

In the concurrently released "Economic Activity and Prices in Japan: Current Situation and Outlook" (the mini Outlook Report), board members Tamura and Takata dissented on the price outlook, as they did with the April Outlook Report. Their reasoning was that underlying inflation has already reached the "price stability target," a view unchanged from their previous dissent. This was not a hawkish surprise; it would have been if they had argued that inflation was already exceeding the target. We can interpret this as one of the reasons why a more aggressive 50bp rate hike was not proposed at this meeting.

The rate hike path implied by the revised forward guidance

The revision to the forward guidance, which we expected would be aimed at securing future policy flexibility, materialized in a different form than anticipated. Specifically, the phrase "real interest rates are at significantly low levels" from the April statement was removed and replaced with "financial conditions have been accommodative."

This change aligns with the conclusions of the BoJ's March BoJ review paper, "[Developments in the Natural Rate of Interest and the Assessment of the Degree of Monetary Accommodation](#)". It suggests a shift away from using direct benchmarks like the natural rate of interest or real interest rates—which are difficult to measure accurately—toward a policy stance based on a broader assessment of

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accommodative financial conditions. However, since the indicators for judging whether "financial conditions are accommodative" are diverse, this gives the BoJ greater discretion.

In our preview memo, we had anticipated a more substantial revision to the guidance, but the wording chosen this time is simpler. Nevertheless, it will take considerable time to determine if financial conditions remain "accommodative" even after a rate hike. This can be taken as an implicit message that the BoJ is not planning aggressive tightening, such as consecutive rate hikes. It also suggests that the Bank does not intend to raise the policy rate into restrictive territory.

Furthermore, if economic conditions consistent with the price stability target are achieved from October 2026 onwards, as the BoJ forecasts, it would be inconsistent for financial conditions to be described as accommodative rather than neutral. Therefore, further revisions to the forward guidance will likely remain a key topic of discussion.

[We maintain our rate hike forecast](#)

Considering the revised forward guidance and the addition of the phrase "there is a risk of underlying CPI inflation deviating upward to a level above the price stability target of 2 percent" to the statement, we see no need to change our forecast for an accelerated pace of rate hikes. We continue to expect the next rate hike in **October, followed by quarterly hikes that will bring the policy rate to 1.75% by April 2027**. We believe this rate hike path is achievable even with the anticipated shift in the policy board's composition toward a more dovish stance.

On the other hand, the scenario of raising the policy rate to 2% at a pace of roughly once every six months, which some in the market have priced in, now faces a higher hurdle following board member Asada's dissent.

[Outright purchases of JGBs: a conspicuously cautious exit](#)

Regarding outright purchases of JGBs, the BoJ decided to maintain its tapering plan through the 1Q 2027, after which it will maintain monthly purchases at around 2 trillion yen from April 2027. This means the tapering of JGB purchases will conclude at the end of March 2027, as was widely expected.

What we find problematic, however, is the justification provided. This time, "improvement of market functioning and stability" was explicitly stated as an objective of JGB purchase operations. While "market stability" was mentioned as a goal for flexible operations at the June 2025 meeting, incorporating both "market functioning" and "stability" into the purpose of the purchases themselves is a new development. We judge that this lowers the psychological and institutional threshold for the BoJ to respond with measures like increased purchases should long-term interest rates spike due to a shock.

As we pointed out in our preview memo, we understand that opinions calling for a halt to the reduction of purchases were in the minority at the prior "Bond Market Participants Meeting." Given the diverse range of views, we find the explanation for the decision to halt the tapering to be insufficient.

[Asymmetry with other policy tools raises accountability questions](#)

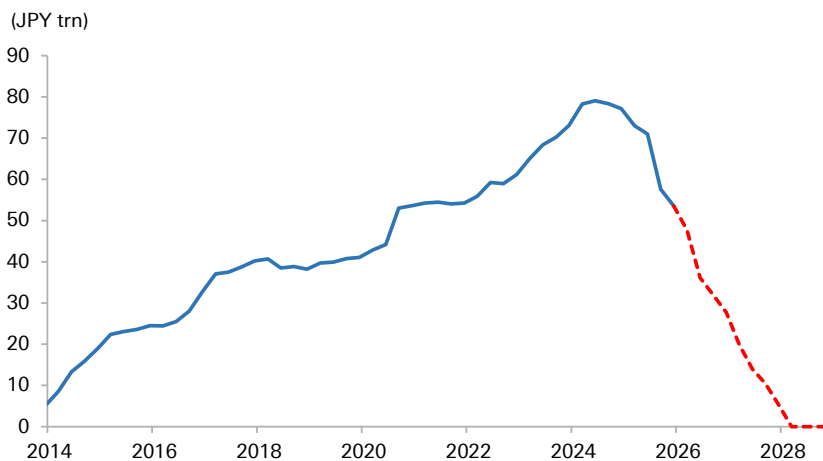
The BoJ's cautious stance on reducing its JGB holdings becomes even more pronounced when compared with its handling of other policy tools.



Forexample, the terms for the "Funds-Supplying Operations to Support an Increase in Lending" (the special lending facility) were tightened in March 2024, and in January 2025 it was decided that new lending would cease at the end of June 2025. This was executed swiftly without public consultation forums akin to the bond market meetings. As a result, the outstanding balance of 71 trillion yen as of June 2025 is expected to fall to zero by March 2028 (see Figure 1). This decision was made rapidly despite its anticipated impact on the financial system, such as reduced demand for JGBs as collateral and the need for banks to find alternative stable funding sources.

Meanwhile, for ETFs, the BoJ announced at its September 2025 meeting a policy to sell them off over a period of more than 100 years. The significant differences in the methods and pace of unwinding for each policy tool have not been adequately and consistently explained by the BoJ. This will likely become a critical point of focus in its future dialogue with the market.

Figure 1: Outlook for outstanding of fund-provisioning measure to stimulate bank lending

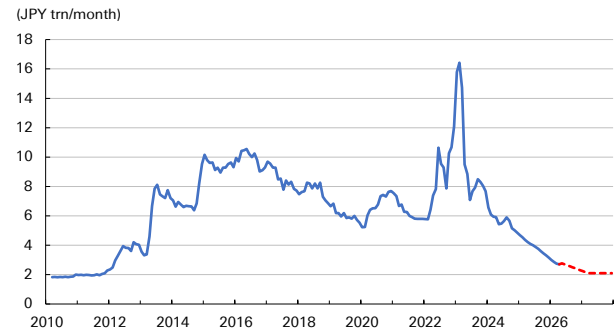


Sources: BoJ, Deutsche Securities

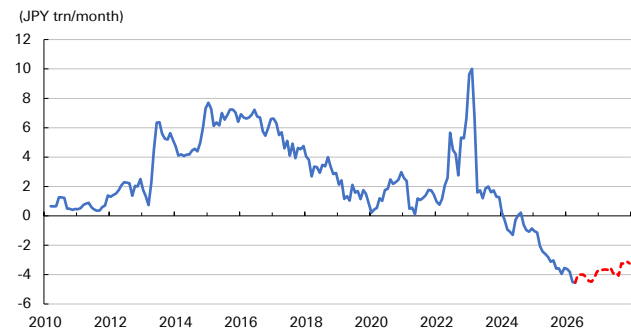


Figure 2: Forecasts for BoJ's JGB holding

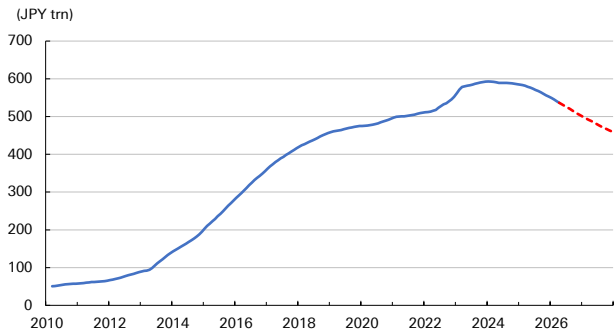
Gross purchase



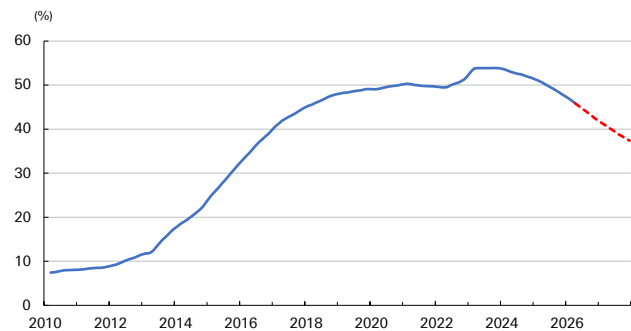
Net purchase



Holding amount



BoJ's holding share as a % of existing JGBs



Note: 3mma. Assumptions: Redemption of BoJ JGB holding is JPY80trn in 2026 and JPY67trn in 2027. New JGB issuance is JPY35trn both for 2026 and 2027.
Sources: BoJ, Deutsche Securities



Appendix 1

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